

newspaper, Pravda. Shostakovich was summoned by Platon Kerzhentsev, the chairman of the USSR State Committee on Culture and denounced for “Formalism”—the catch-all criticism aimed at those who ignored the tastes of the proletariat, and did not write music that sought to glorify the Soviet state.

Shostakovich thus struggled to find work as a composer. He had finished his Fourth Symphony, but withdrew it before its first performance, fearing further sanctions or even worse, as Stalin had his political opponents and their supporters summarily removed.

In a bid to restore his reputation, he completed the Fifth Symphony in 1937, which was written in a less challenging style. Dubbed by the establishment as “a Soviet artist’s creative response to just criticism,” the symphony was accepted as a gesture of good faith, and Shostakovich was offered a post at the Leningrad Conservatory to teach composition.



*THE NOSE*

Based on a satirical short story by Nikolai Gogol, Shostakovich’s opera *The*